

Global Spelling Style Guide

Baseline Dictionaries: (for uncovered entries)

British English: Oxford English Dictionary (using -ize endings) or Collins (using -ise endings)

American English: Merriam-Webster (MW) or Oxford American

Canadian English: Oxford Canadian Dictionary

Australian English: Macquarie Dictionary or Australian Oxford Dictionary

SPELLING EXCEPTIONS IN ALL ENGLISH DIALECTS

Accents: Optional but permissive in loanwords like “café” and “cafe” while “naïve” and “naive”. Always required in names or names of ethnic groups, ie Métis, Brontë or José. Do not put accents if a word is always accepted without accents even do traditionalists, like “elite” or “hotel”.

Hyphens: Hyphenate before the noun, not after the noun: the actor is well known, a well-known actor.

Numbers: Spell out 1-10. Never start a sentence with a number. Advisable to use phrases like “a total number of...” to avoid violating this rule.

#

4chan

8chan

A

abettor

accommodation

acknowledgement is the preferred spelling in BrE and Australian English,
acknowledgment in Canadian and American English.

adapter, adaptor: both are acceptable, but adapter is always preferred for tech

advice (noun), advise (verb)

adviser (not advisor), but advisory

adze

aegis

aeon (philosophy / sci-fi)

aerie

aesthetic (note: use ae)

affect (v), effect (n) generally

African American (not African-American)

Afrobeats

Afrodescendant (noun), Afrodescendent (adj)

AI

aide-de-camp

aircraft or plane (not airplane)

Åland Islands

all right

a lot

aluminium (preferred, recommended spellings) for scientific contexts

alumni (most common), alum (gender-neutral US slang)

amid (not amidst)

amok

among (not amongst)

analogue (noun) (preferred spelling globally as a noun), analog watch

annex (verb), annexe (noun BrE, Australian, Canadian), annex (US)

anti-American

antibiotic

anti-bumping granules

anticlockwise (US: counterclockwise)

antidote

anti-free market

antifreeze

anti-hate speech

antiperspirant

antisemitism

antiseptic

antisocial

antithesis (plural antitheses)

anti-war

apartheid

appendices

apropos

archaeology (note: use ae)

argument

artifact

Asian American

audiobook

Australian Labor Party

avocados

axe

B

backlash

Baghdad

balk

bandana

banister

banyan (not banian)

barbecue

barcode

baseline

battalion

bauble

bazaar

Bedouin

bee-eater

benefited, benefiting

bestseller

biannual, biennial, bimonthly, biweekly

biased

bivouac, bivouacking

BlackBerries

blond (used for all genders, not blonde)

bogey

bogeyman

bourgeois

braille

bravado

breathe (verb), breath (noun)

briquette

bumblebee

bumf (not bumph)

buncombe

Bunsen burner

burqa

businessperson (one word)

buses (not busses)

C

cacti

caddy (preferred for containers / devices) / caddie (golf assistant)

caesar salad

caesium (preferred scientifically), cesium is a US variant

caffeine, cafeteria (never put an accent even if café takes one)

caliph

calligraphy

callus (noun for hard skin), callous (adj for heartless)

cancellation (note: cancelled/cancelling remains a regional split)

canister

cannot

carat

carburettor (British / Australian), carburetor (US)

carousel

casket

cater-corner

caviar

cellphone (one word)

chameleon

changelog

chastity

château

cheque (refers to the bank sense), check (US spelling only of the bank sense)

cipher

cliché, clichéd

chilli (British, Australian preferred), chili (American), “Chile” reserves for the Southwestern US for the pepper itself,

clue

co-author

Coca-Cola

cocoa

coconut

co-ed (co-educational)

coequal

coexist

co-founder

collectable

combated

committee

complement (add to enhance sth), compliment (praise)

connection

convener

coolly (never cooly because it can be a racial slur)

co-op, multiplayer

cooperate

cooperation

cooperative

co-opt

coordinate

coordination

cornerstone

cosy (preferred in British, Australian, Oxford), cozy is a US variant

counter-argument

counter-attack

counterbalance

counter-example

counterproductive

counter-revolutionary

co-worker, co-working

czar

D

daycare

daytime

debatable

definitely

de-emphasise (British, Australian), de-emphasize (not deemphasize) (American, Canadian)

dependable

desiccate

de-escalate

dexterous

diagrammed

diarrhoea (British and Australian), diarrhea (American and Canadian)

diaspora

diesel (lowercase)

dietitian

dike

disk (computing), disc (circular objects)

diskette

dispatch

dived (not dove)

doughnut

dreamed (not dreamt)

drier (adj), dryer (noun)

drought

dryly

duffel

E

earned

ebook

ecology

eczema

e-commerce

eerie

e-learning

email

embarrass

embed

emoji (plural emojis)

enclose

encumbrance

encyclopedia

endorse

engraft

enquire, inquire: acceptable and interchangeable, though sometimes using enquire for general asking while inquire for official investigations

ensure (make certain that will occur), insure (arrange for compensation)

entrust

eon (used in geology) see aeon

e-sports

euro

Eurocentric

everyday (adj), every day (noun)

F

faeces (British, Australian preferred), feces is the American spelling.

faggot (not fagot) for the British meatball form, but try to avoid this word

fantasy

far-left, far-right

fascia

feldspar

ferrule

fetal

fetid

fetus

fiberglass

fiery

filigree

flaky

flamboyant

fledgling

flutist

flyer (paper pamphlet), flier (a person who travels on a plane)

focused

foray

forbade

Forebear (an ancestor), forbear (to abstain from sth)

forever

foreword (introductory section), forward (direction of movement or progress), use forwards in BrE, Australian or Canadian English, forward in AmE.

forgo (abstain from), forego (to go before)

formulas (used for tech / general contexts)

formulae (used for maths / chemistry contexts)

Frédéric Chopin

fundraising

G

gaily (not gayly)

gases

gauge

gauze, as in wire gauze

gelatin

ghetto, ghettos

gibe – means “for a mocking taunt”, jibe means “in agreement with” and gybe for “sailing a boat”

gigabyte

glamour, but glamorous

glazier

gluing

goodbye

gourmand

gram (never gramme)

grey

greyhound

grizzly (bear or grey hair), grisly (for something gruesome)

groundbreaking

grovel

guerrilla

guillemot

guttural

gymnasia (singular is gymnasium)

Gypsy (not Gipsy, and recommended to use Romani instead)

gyre

gyro

H

haemorrhage (British and Australian), hemorrhage (American and Canadian)

halfway

Hallelujah

Halloween

Hanafi

Hanukkah

harakiri

harelip (avoid; use cleft lip instead)

hauler

Hawai'i, but Hawaiian

healthcare

Heaven-sent

hectogram

hello (not hallo, hullo)

heresy

heroin (drug) heroine (female of hero)

hertz

heterogenous

hiccup

hindrance

hippy

historical novel, historic, a (not "an" historical novel / "an" historic)

homemade

homeopathy

honorific

I

idyll

iMac

impostor

indexes (back of books or general metrics), indices (mathematical, statistical)

Indigenous Peoples

inextricable

inoculate

install

internet, the

Into

Inuk (singular of Inuit)

iodine

iPad

iPhone

Irish Traveller

iTunes

J

jail

jacquard

janissary

jasmine

jelly (not jello)

jerky

jiffy

ji

jingoism

jockeyed, jockeying

jodhpurs

jonquil

joust

judgment, legal (universal), judgement is accepted in BrE and AusE for the moral or general sense

jujitsu

Junker

junk food

K

Kaddish

kaffir lime (avoid, use makrut lime)

kaiser

kaleidoscope

kangaroo

kaolin

karma

kayak

kebab

kedge

keffiyeh

keratin

ketchup

khaki

Khedive

kidnapped

kilogram

kindergarten

Ku Klux Klan

Kyiv

L

Labour Day (Hong Kong), Labour Party (UK)

laggard

lambaste

lanolin

lapel

lassos

Latino (Male), Latina (Female), Latiné (Gender-neutral emerging), never Latinx

lavender

layout

leaned (not leant)

leaped (not leapt)

learned (not “learnt”)

leister

LGBT+, LGBTQ+, LGBTQIA+, 2SLGBTQIA+

licence (preferred noun in Commonwealth), license (preferred verb in Commonwealth), in US English use license for everything.

lifestyle

linchpin

liquefy

liveability (British, Australian), livability (US)

livestream(ing)

llama is the animal, lama means a Tibetan monk

long-term (hyphenated before a noun, long term after a noun)

lovable

lowlife

low-veld

M

malign

manageable

man-made (avoid; preferred alternatives: artificial or synthetic)

manoeuvre (British, Canadian, Australian), maneuver is an Americanism.

Māori (plural remains: the Māori)

marijuana

matrices

medieval (not mediaeval)

memento

Métis peoples

microaggression

microorganism

mid-'90s

midday

midseason

midsummer

Milestone

millennium

minikin

minuscule (never “miniscule”)

Mohawk

mollusc

monarchies

money (plural moneys)

moneyed

monkeyed

Moorish

Morocco

mottoes

movable

Mum (not mom)

multicultural

multi-ethnic

multimedia

Muslim (not Moslem)

must-have

N

naïveté / naivety (must be consistent, both are accepted) but never “naiveté”

nationwide

naught (US), nought (British and Commonwealth)

naughty

necessary

net (not nett)

network

nevertheless

newsfeed

nexus (is the plural already)

night-time
nineteen
ninja
nomad
nonetheless
non-binary
nonconforming
non-cooperation
nondescript
non-existent
nonfeasance
non-profit
no one
nuclei (not nucleuses)



occurrence
offline
ogre
okay (OK is a shorthand which should be avoided in semi-formal and formal writing)
omelette – is the preferred spelling in the UK, Canada and Australia. Omelet is used in AmE.
omitting

online

onomatopoeia (note: use oe)

opportune

orangutan

oriented

outnumber

outperform

out-thinking

overcrowded

overexploitation

overfishing

oyes

P

pancake

pandemonium

panicked

papoose

parakeet

paralleled

parallelism

passer-by (plural passers-by)

passed (action of movement), past (for time or distance beyond a point)

pastime

peephole

Pegasus

peony

per annum

per capita

percent, percentage

per diam

pharaoh

phial

phoenix

phony

pigeon

pizzazz

polypus (plural polypi)

postcode

post–cold war

postgraduate, undergraduate

postmodern

postnatal

post-war

post-WWII

practice (noun/universal), practise (British/Canadian/Commonwealth verb),

practice (used for everything in AmE)

preallocated

predate

pre-eclampsia

pre-embryo

pre-eminence

pre-eminent

pre-empt

pre-establish

pre-existing

prejudice

pre-recorded

preregister

pre-release

prerequisite

preschool

principle (truth / law), principal (a person of high authority)

Pride (capitalised) but gay pride

prologue

promoter

protester

program, computer

pseudoscience

psychology

publicly

pygmy

Q

quartet

quay

query

queuing (preferred alternative: lining up)

quintuplet

Qur'an

R

raccoon

racket

rajah

rarefy

ratafia

reaction

README

reallocate

redo

re-edit

re-elect

re-emerge

re-employ

re-enact

re-enfranchise

re-engage

re-engineer

re-enrol (British / Australian / Canadian), re-enroll (US) (not reenroll)

re-enter

re-equip

re-establish

re-evaluate

re-examine

re-export

referable

reinforce (not re-enforce)

résumé: also “resume” but never “resumé” with putting 1 accent for the last “e”

rhyme

rhythm

rigmarole

routing

run-in

S

saccharin

satchel

sautéed (not sauté)

seething

sere (sth withered or dry), sear (to burn sth)

setup (noun), set up (phr verb)

scissors

sheikh

shish kebab

siphon

sizeable (British, Australian), sizable (US)

skeptic

smartphone

snaffle

sneaked (not snuck)

softlock

soundtrack

southern hemisphere (not capitalised)

spamming

standalone

startup culture

stationary (not moving), stationery (pencils, eraser, ruler etc)

storey (compare with: story)

straitjacket

sub-Saharan Africa

sulfide

sulfur

supersede

sylvan

T

taboo

taffeta

tarmac

tattoo

teaspoonfuls

textbook

thimblery

tidbit

tikka

TikTok

tithe

thesis (plural theses, also hypothesis, hypotheses)

today

toffee

tomorrow

tollbooth

tourniquet

tranquillity (preferred British, Canadian, Australian), tranquility (US)

trousseau

turnip

tympanum (plural tympana)

U

UK, US (full stops redundant)

unbiased

uncommunicative

uncooperative

underlining

under way: avoid, use ongoing instead

UNESCO (not Unesco)

update

upgrade

uproot

up-to-date (pre-noun), up to date (after noun)

urinalysis (plural urinalyses)

usable

username

UTF-8, UTF-16

U-turn

V

vapour (British / Commonwealth), vapor (AmE), vaporous (never vapourous, which is a misspelling like humour/humorous pairs in British English), vaporise / vaporize (no u, but ise and ize depend on your dictionary, vaporise British Australian, vaporize Canadian American)

vase

vaudeville

velveteen

ventriloquist

veranda

vice-principal

vice versa

videotape

vigour (British, Australian, Canadian), vigor (US), but vigorous (always no u)

vise (use this spelling for the tool to avoid confusion)

visor

vitamin

voicemail

W

watt

warfare

warpath

wash house

weasel

website, webpage

wellbeing

well-known (pre-noun), well known (post-noun)

werewolf

while (not whilst)

whimsy

whippoorwill

whiskey

Wi-Fi

wintry

withhold

wizard

wizened

workforce

World Health Organization

worldwide

worthwhile

X

xanthophyll

x-coordinate

xenophobia

X-ray